

Committee who was also camping in the Capital last week, leading a delegation of NRIs who called on BJP's Arun Shourie, and Rajnath, CPI's D. Raja, and Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. Washington is wooing the Indian-American community, and especially those influential members of the Overseas Friends of BJP, some of them leading doctors and professionals who have invested their time, energy and even money supporting the deal. "Indian Americans are feeling let down because many of them spent their money and energy lobbying for the deal and now they have lost face," says Naresh Chandra, former Indian ambassador to the US.

Meanwhile, the Americans made a renewed effort to woo the Left with Paulson's meeting with Bhattacharya in Kolkata last weekend. CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat continued to state in Delhi that the Left had not softened its position on the issue. In an interview published in *The Telegraph*, the CPI(M) chief was quoted as saying, "The prime minister's integrity is unquestioned." CPI(M) sources say that it was Karat's strategy to praise Manmohan in the very newspaper in which the prime minister had dared the Left to withdraw support to the UPA Government over the nuclear face-off. After discussing the current political situation with DMK chief K. Karunanidhi in Chennai recently, Karat's confidence has grown. DMK has openly backed the Left's position on the deal while RJD and NCP have tempered their tacit support by cautioning Congress President Sonia Gandhi on the political consequences the deal's execution might have. The Left may have praised Manmohan but it has no plan of backing the deal. In fact, in exchange of the deal's demise, there is promise of more nice words from Karat for the prime minister.

Manmohan, though, seems unwilling to yield easily. "Efforts are on to evolve a broad-based consensus. We are a democracy. Ultimately, we have to take all those who support us. We have not reached the end of the road," Manmohan said during a media interaction with German Chancellor Angela Merkel. "It is an honourable deal which is good for India and the world



TURNING LEFT: Paulson (right) tries to sell the nuke deal to Bhattacharya

and for non-proliferation. We have run into problems. We are trying to resolve the matter. As far as the Government is concerned, we remain committed to the deal," the prime minister added, signalling to his international interlocutors that India will not renege from its international commitment. The message was significant considering that Germany is also the current chair

of the 44-member Nuclear Suppliers Group, which has to approve an exception clause before any nuclear commerce can take place with India.

Even as the prime minister maintained that all was not lost, other channels were working overtime using all their levers to push for the deal. US Secretary of State Condoleezza Rice spoke to External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee. While Rice made it clear that US cannot renegotiate the deal, she told Mukherjee that time was running out and India should take the next steps soon as any further delay will make it difficult for the administration to push the deal. This is something Mulford told BJP leaders as well.

Sources say, even as the multi-pronged exercise to salvage the deal is on, the Government is considering several possibilities while one possibility is that UPA will persuade the Left to allow it to freeze the text of the IAEA safeguards agreement, and may offer it at the November 16 meeting. That is the indication Mukherjee is believed to have conveyed to the Left leaders when he again spoke to them on October 29. For the outcome, watch the Parliament session beginning on November 15. *with Satarupa Bhattacharya*

AMERICAN BLITZ

October 24: Mulford calls on L.K. Advani. Tells him this is BJP's deal. Stresses on the time schedule.

October 26: Mulford meets Brajesh Mishra and tries to allay his concerns.

October 28: US Treasury Secretary Henry Paulson tells Buddhadeb Bhattacharya the deal is in India's economic and strategic interests.

October 29: Henry Kissinger meets Advani. Calls it a landmark deal.

October 29: Mulford tells Rajnath Singh that if the deal falls through, it could impact Indo-US relations.

October 29 Condoleezza Rice warns Pranab Mukherjee against delay.